MODULE 10

CASE STUDY

Linear: The Anti-Feature Company

How saying NO to features built a better product management tool than Jira

Prepare this case before class. Come ready to take a position.

THE SITUATION

Linear, 2020

Karri Saarinen left Airbnb's design team to build Linear — a project management tool that works the way designers and engineers actually think. Linear has 500 paying teams. Users constantly request: Gantt charts, time tracking, resource management, custom fields, and a mobile app.

Jira (the market leader) has all of these. Notion, Asana, and Monday.com are also expanding. Linear ships small improvements weekly — but has capacity for only ~2 major feature bets per YEAR.

KEY FACTS

- 500 paying teams
- 8-person engineering team
- ~2 major feature bets per year
- Jira: dominant, full-featured competitor
- User requests: Gantt, time tracking, mobile
- Core differentiator: speed + simplicity

THE DECISION

Which features should Linear build next? How do they decide what NOT to build?

OPTION A

Build the most-requested features — Gantt charts and time tracking satisfy the most users

OPTION B

Build what deepens the core — invest in speed, keyboard shortcuts, and workflow automation

OPTION C

Build a mobile app — it's table stakes and the competition all has one

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Come prepared to defend your position with evidence from the case.

1. Apply the 3-Question Filter to each feature request: Has someone asked? 10x better? Build by hand?
1. When customers ask for Gantt charts, what job are they really trying to do?
1. How do you say 'no' to paying customers without losing them?
1. What's the relationship between product identity and feature decisions?